CONTEXTUAL INTERPRETATION

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Functional English (SS1012)

CONTEXTUAL INTERPRETATION

In language, contextual interpretation is the process of understanding the meaning of words, phrases, and messages by considering the surrounding situation, background, and purpose of communication, rather than just their word for word definitions. It involves using various clues—like the relationship between speakers, the setting, cultural background, and the overall flow of the conversation or text—to accurately infer the intended message and communicate effectively in real-world situations.

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PURPOSE

- **To Inform:**

  To provide readers with facts, data, and new knowledge about a topic.
  - **Examples:** Textbooks, news articles, instructions, and informational brochures.
- **To Persuade:**

  To convince the audience to agree with a particular idea, opinion, or course of action.
  - **Examples:** Advertisements, political speeches, opinion editorials, and argumentative essays.
- **To Entertain:**

  To amuse, bring enjoyment, or evoke emotion in the reader.
  - **Examples:** Novels, stories, poems, jokes, and other forms of narrative or creative writing.

TONE

The tone of a passage is the writer's attitude or feeling about the subject that he or she is presenting.

Tone is the author's voice and attitude towards the subject, the audience, and the characters.

EVERY AUTHOR ADOPTS A CERTAIN ATTITUDE TOWARDS THE ISSUE HE IS TALKING ABOUT

Some wish to highlight the facts about a matter (thereby adopting a 'factual' tone)

some wish to explore the pros and cons of a decision (thereby adopting a 'critical' tone)

some wish to explore each and every aspect, cause, effect and so on with regards to a certain topic (thereby adopting an 'analytical' tone)

some wish to narrate an instance from their life (thereby adopting a 'sentimental/narrative' tone)

some wish to express their emotions, happy or sad (thereby adopting 'emotional/happy/grief-stricken' tones).

WHY IS TONE IMPORTANT IN A STORY?

Tone helps engage with your target audience and provoke a particular feeling and emotion in the reader.

In business writing, a more formal tone can help you present an organized, confident attitude.

In storytelling, a casual or playful tone can help you bring your reader closer to your characters.

Because the reader can't see the writer's facial expression or body language when they're conveying an idea, the author's word choice and writing style is essential.

TYPES OF TONE YOU MIGHT SEE IN A STORY

Cheerful	I can't wait to get to the party!
Pessimistic	This party is going to be a disaster.
Hopeful	This party could change everything for me.
Optimistic	We're going to have a great time, and absolutely nothing will go wrong.
Melancholy	I remember the parties of my younger days. Things were simpler then…
Arrogant	I hope they realize how lucky they are to have me on their guest list.
Cheerful	I can't wait to get to the party!

TYPES OF TONE YOU MIGHT SEE IN A STORY

Fearful	**But what if I make a fool of myself and nobody likes me?**
Humorous	It's not a party, it's a poolside zoo.
Desperate	I *need* to make this party count.
Persuasive	Don't worry, a vacation is exactly what you need.
Inspirational	Sometimes, all it takes is one magical moment to turn your life around.
Fearful	But what if I make a fool of myself and nobody likes me?

BIAS

Bias is a tendency to lean in a certain direction, either in favor or against a particular thing.

To be truly biased means to lack a neutral viewpoint on a particular topic.

It is also defined as

- a prejudice against something an author is writing about

A favoritism for something a writer is writing about

Bias in writing occurs when the writer has a specific opinion or a preference for one thing over another.

When this occurs, the writing is no longer accurate or impartial as it has been swayed by personal opinions or beliefs.

GENDER BIASED LANGUAGE

One of the most discussed forms of this phenomenon is gender-biased language.

It is a sub-form of language bias based, as the name suggests, on language use that perpetuates certain stereotypes of genders or stresses superiority of one gender over the other.

EXAMPLE

There are many languages that tend to promote a male/masculine-centric worldview in which the female/feminine is subordinate. Just look at these English words:

mankind

man-made

man hours

forefathers

There are also plenty of words that make automatic assumptions about the gender of the person occupying certain roles or occupations:

chairman

housewife

fireman

cleaning lady

salesman

OTHER BIASED LANGUAGE EXAMPLES

Age — Calling older people “the elderly” or “the aged”.

Ability or health status — Describing people with different abilities or health conditions as “wheelchair-bound” or “victims” of a disease.

Religion — Referring to members of one religion as “fanatic” and to those of another as “devout”.

Race and ethnicity — Using “blacklist” and “whitelist” instead of “blocked list” and “allowed list” in software solutions. This implies that “black” is somehow bad while “white” is good.

Social class — Labeling people as “poor” or “lower class” to describe their socioeconomic status.

HOW TO AVOID?

Practice Using Gender-Neutral Language

*If a student wants to take part in the class trip, **he** needs a permission slip.*

*If a student wants to take part in the class trip, **he or she** needs a permission slip.*

*If **students** want to take part in the class trip, **they** need a permission slip.*

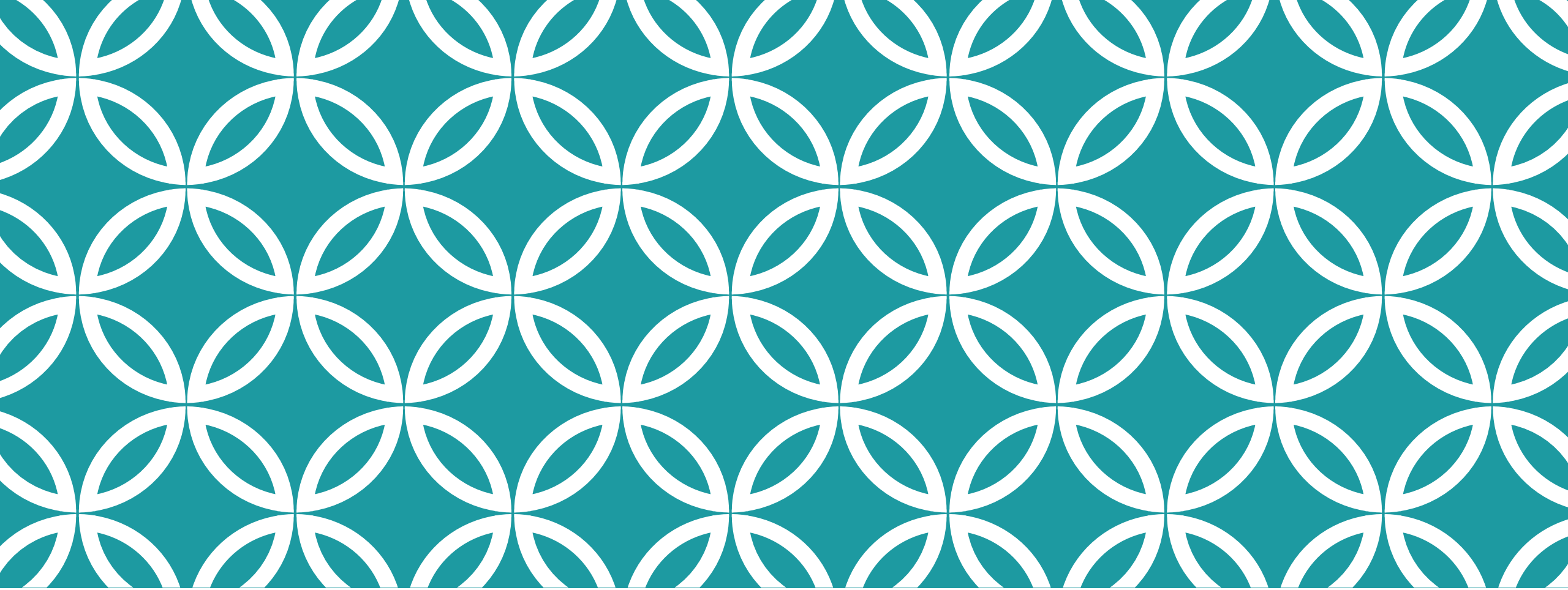
Every student who wants to take part in the class trip needs a permission slip.

A SECOND STEP IS TO REPLACE GENDERED WORDS WITH GENDER-NEUTRAL ALTERNATIVES.

Gendered words	Alternative
mankind	humanity
mailman	postal worker
to man the front desk	to staff the front desk
forefathers	ancestors
fireman	fire fighter
housewife	homemaker

LEARN ALTERNATIVES FOR OTHER BIASED LANGUAGE

Biased terminology	Alternative
the elderly	older people, people over the age of X
wheelchair-bound	a person using a wheelchair
non-white people	people of color, BIPOC (Black, Indigenous, and People of Color)
poor people	people earning less than X
disabled people	people with disabilities



TYPES OF BIAS

CONFIRMATION BIAS

Confirmation bias occurs when the writer consciously or unconsciously cherry-picks facts and evidence that support what they already believe to be true.

This kind of bias often leads to false conclusions and can sometimes be hard to recognize by the writer.

e.g. "*The XYZ diet proves that calorie counting leads to permanent weight loss*" (some calorie-counting diets don't lead to permanent weight loss.)

ANCHORING BIAS

Anchoring bias occurs when the writer relies too heavily on a single source of information or opinion.

This can lead to an inaccurate representation of what is actually true, as well as distorted conclusions.

e.g. "*Globalization has been a net positive force for the economy*" (or a net negative force, if you take the opposing view.)

GROUPTHINK BIAS

Groupthink bias involves showing favoritism towards a person, entity, etc. because it belongs or identifies with the same group as you. This can lead to tribalism, prejudice and misguided opinions.

e.g. "*Football fans are the most loyal compared to any other sport*" (substitute football with your sport of choice.)

CULTURAL BIAS

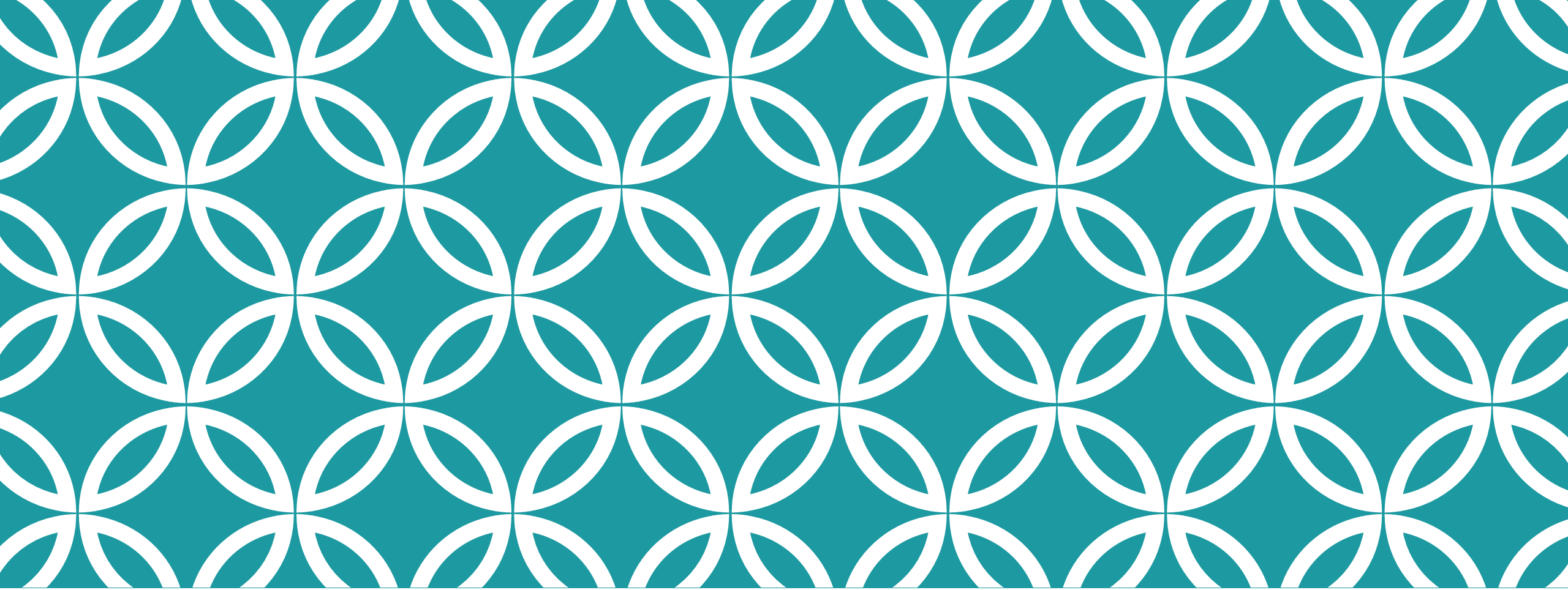
Cultural bias refers to the tendency of some people to privilege certain cultural beliefs or norms over others.

e.g. *"The practice of the x meditation technique is the best path to a balanced life"* (how about y or z?)

GENERALIZATION BIAS

Generalization bias takes place when the same 'catch-all' filter is applied to large groups of people, professions, entities, etc. treating them as a single block, when in reality there are clear differences among group members.

e.g. "*People in the x, y, or z demographic always vote democrat*" (substitute democrat for republican or independent.)



STEREOTYPES

STEREOTYPES

The language used to make preconceived judgements or assumptions about a person or group of people.

Stereotypes are formed through our observations of others in daily life, which is then reflected in the language we use to refer to specific groups of people in society.

REASONS FOR USING STEREOTYPES

According to psychologist Henri Tajfel (1981)[1], stereotypes can be used to make generalized assumptions about groups of people to simplify the world around us.

Stereotypes can be true in some cases, but most of the time, they are not.

It is important to be aware that stereotypes are often **not** accurate representations of groups of people; they are based on broad expectations and should not be taken as complete facts.

Stereotyping groups of people can be harmful to the representation of individuals, as it can simplify the differences between people and undermine someone's uniqueness.

CULTURAL STEREOTYPES

This refers to broad generalizations of people from different cultures in different countries.

For example:

British people have a ‘stiff upper lip’ (don't show much emotion) and drink tea a lot.

Americans are loud and patriotic.

All Chinese people know martial arts.

French people wear stripy shirts.

SOCIAL STEREOTYPES

This refers to the preconceived ideas of people in different social groups, which includes: age, class, skill etc. Examples include:

Teenagers are irresponsible.

Upper-class people are posh and 'stuck up'.

Lower-class people are lazy and not as smart.

RACIAL STEREOTYPES

This refers to the assumed characteristics of a particular race. These are often considered to be the most negative, as they can lead to bias and discrimination, harmfully representing certain races. Some less offensive examples include:

Black people are athletic and tall.

Asians are good at maths.

GENDER STEREOTYPES

This refers to the assumptions made about the characteristics of different genders. They can frequently lead to an unfair bias towards a particular gender. They are also used to compare the way people should behave based on their genders. Because of this, certain genders may face discrimination or inequality due to how they are perceived by others.

EXAMPLES OF MALE GENDER STEREOTYPES ARE:

Men don't talk about their feelings.

Men are stronger than women.

Men are smarter than women.

Men who are not assertive are 'unmanly'.

EXAMPLES OF FEMALE GENDER STEREOTYPES ARE:

Women are overly emotional and sensitive.

Women are weaker than men.

Women are not as smart as men.

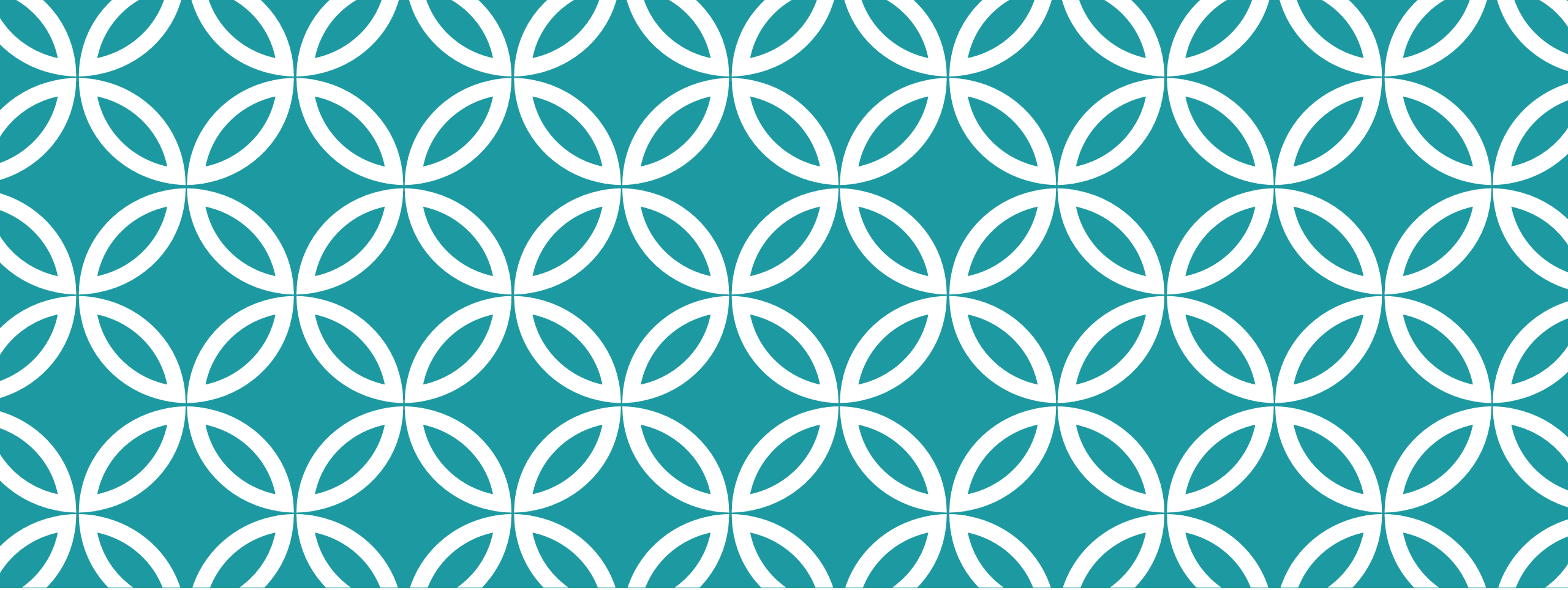
Women gossip a lot.

RELIGIOUS STEREOTYPES

This refers to preconceived beliefs of particular people in different religions. They are often used to discriminate against certain religions, which can cause conflict between different religious groups and portray religions in a negative light. They also negatively affect the perception of religious individuals; instead of highlighting the extreme acts of a few people, religious stereotypes make generalisations which lead to people assuming that entire religious groups are capable of such things. Examples include:

Muslims are terrorists.

Christians are overly judgmental.



INFERENCE

INFERENCE

An inference is the process of drawing a conclusion from supporting evidence.

It's when you go *beyond* the evidence and reach some further conclusion.

We also make inferences when we read literature. The author gives us clues about what's going on, and we have to figure things out based on that evidence.

The author *implies*; the readers *infer*.

We draw inferences all the time when we say things like:

“I don’t see Anne. She said she was tired, so she must have gone home to bed.”

“Sarah’s been at the gym a lot; she must be trying to lose weight.”

“Jacko is a dog, and all dogs love belly rubs. So Jacko must love belly rubs.”

EXAMPLE 1

You're about to enter a classroom. It's 8:57, and there is lots of chatter coming from inside the room.

–> You infer that there's a 9:00 class that hasn't started yet.

In this example, we have some basic evidence (the time and the noise), and we can infer that class hasn't started yet. We can't be sure that the inference is correct, but it's reasonable to reach this conclusion anyway.

EXAMPLE 2

Socrates is a man, and all men are mortal.

*–>Therefore, we can **infer** that Socrates is mortal.*

This is the most logically complete form of inference. Unlike Example #1, we actually *can* be sure this time. If the evidence is correct, then we can be quite certain that Socrates is mortal.

EXAMPLE 3

Harry's face turned red and he started to yell, balling his hands up into shaking fists.

It's not to hard to infer what Harry's feeling here. From the evidence of his face, voice, and hands, we infer that he's really angry about something, though we don't yet know what it is.

THE IMPORTANCE OF INFERENCES

Without inferences, there's no way we could understand our world. It's all well and good to ask for evidence and proof, but sooner or later we inevitably have to go beyond the evidence and actually draw a conclusion!